



Managing and Resolving Conflict

Conflict can happen in any business and at any level. While debate can lead to a positive outcome, constant arguing will undermine your business unless you learn how to manage and resolve it.

Understanding conflict

Most disputes that occur within your team will be short-lived and minor, and it is impossible to prevent them all. Instead, aim to limit the damaging aspects of any friction between colleagues. Make sure to resolve any conflicts that occur between yourself and team members, tailoring your approach to the situation. Take advantage of new ideas or outcomes that result.

Resolving conflict between people can be time-consuming. Learn when to intervene and

when to simply observe and monitor. Take action only when you have to, and encourage individuals to take responsibility for finding a solution. When serious conflicts arise, speak to those involved but look beyond what people tell you (see box, right) for the real reasons behind the issue. It is important to be calm, rational, and unbiased. Do not be drawn into the argument, but try to put people at ease. Listen carefully to what they are saying and look for evidence to back it up.

Preventing conflict

The best way to prevent unhealthy conflict is to create a working environment in which everyone feels able to say what they think and express their feelings. This will help stop problems from escalating. If, for example, someone is feeling under pressure to meet a deadline but they do not feel able to ask for support, they may become stressed. This can then result in a loss of confidence, leading perhaps to a period of absence from work and feelings of tension

Handling conflict

In 1974, American professors of management Ken Thomas and Ralph Kilmann published a model for resolving conflict. Widely used today, it sets out five possible approaches. Most people have a natural preference for one of the approaches, but understanding and being able to utilize all five modes will help you handle conflicts with or among your colleagues more effectively. With trivial issues, for example, avoiding can be the best approach. However, for issues that must be resolved decisively, competing may be the better option.

Avoiding

This approach involves withdrawing from a situation or postponing dealing with the conflict until a better time. It works for minor issues, such as trivial disagreements, when you cannot invest time or effort.

Accommodating

This means accepting another person's position at the expense of your own. The opposite of competing, this approach is helpful when you know that your colleague is right or you want to protect a working relationship.